# Kazuki Yano

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## Summary

I am a second-year Ph.D. student at Tohoku University working on large language model pre-training, training dynamics, and efficient model scaling, with recent research on multimodal foundation models and adapting text LLMs to new modalities. I have first-author publications at leading venues including **ICLR 2026**, **INTERSPEECH 2026**, **COLM 2025**, and **NAACL 2025**. I have hands-on experience in end-to-end large-scale model training, including pre-training, post-training, and controlled analysis on high-performance compute clusters.

## Education

**Tohoku University** Sendai, Japan
**Ph.D. in Information Science** (expected) 2025 – 2028
**M.S. in Information Science** 2023 – 2025
Supervisor for both degrees: Jun Suzuki

**Carnegie Mellon University** Oct 2026 – Mar 2027
*Visiting Scholar*
WAVLab, Language Technologies Institute
Advisor: Shinji Watanabe

## Experience

**Amazon Japan G.K.** Jun 2026 – Sep 2026
*Research Fellow*

- Developed LLM-based personalized recommendation, including user persona modeling and candidate reranking.

**SB Intuitions** Nov 2024 – May 2026
*Research Intern*

- Conducted LLM development on a large compute cluster, spanning pre-training and post-training.

**Preferred Networks Inc.** Aug 2024 – Mar 2025
*Research Intern*

- Built synthetic-data pipelines for LLM training; evaluated continued pre-training (CPT) and supervised fine-tuning (SFT).

**Rakuten Group, Inc.** Jul 2024 – May 2025
*Data Scientist (Part-time)*

- Studied representation/activation steering for style control via inference-time interventions.

**LINE Corporation** Aug 2023 – Sep 2023
*Research Intern*

- Developed an efficient adversarial-prompt optimization method for safety stress-testing aligned dialogue LMs.

## Publications

**Adapting Text LLMs to Speech via Multimodal Depth Up-Scaling**
**Kazuki Yano**, Jun Suzuki, and Shinji Watanabe
*INTERSPEECH 2026* [Paper]

**Pre-training LLM without Learning Rate Decay Enhances Supervised Fine-Tuning**
**Kazuki Yano**, Shun Kiyono, Sosuke Kobayashi, Sho Takase, and Jun Suzuki
*ICLR 2026* [Paper]

## Publications (continued)

**TimeMachine-bench: A Benchmark on Evaluating Model's Capability on Repository-level Migration Tasks**
Ryo Fujii, Makoto Morishita, **Kazuki Yano**, and Jun Suzuki
*EACL 2026* [Paper]

**Suppressing Final Layer Hidden State Jumps in Transformer Pretraining**
Keigo Shibata, **Kazuki Yano**, Ryosuke Takahashi, Wataru Ikeda, and Jun Suzuki
*Findings of EACL 2026* [Paper]

**Efficient Construction of Model Family through Progressive Training Using Model Expansion**
**Kazuki Yano**, Sho Takase, Sosuke Kobayashi, Shun Kiyono, and Jun Suzuki
*COLM 2025* [Paper]

**Layer-wise Importance Analysis of Feed-Forward Networks in Transformer-based Language Models**
Wataru Ikeda, **Kazuki Yano**, Ryosuke Takahashi, Jaesung Lee, Keigo Shibata, and Jun Suzuki
*COLM 2025* [Paper]

**STEP: Staged Parameter-Efficient Pre-training for Large Language Models**
**Kazuki Yano**, Takumi Ito, and Jun Suzuki
*NAACL 2025* [Paper]

**Document-level Translation with LLM Reranking: Team-J at WMT 2024 General Translation Task**
Keito Kudo, Hiroyuki Deguchi, Makoto Morishita, Ryo Fujii, Takumi Ito, Shintaro Ozaki, Koki Natsumi, Kai Sato, **Kazuki Yano**, Ryosuke Takahashi, Subaru Kimura, Tomomasa Hara, Yusuke Sakai, and Jun Suzuki
*WMT 2024* [Paper]

**STEP: Staged Parameter-Efficient Pre-training for Large Language Models**
**Kazuki Yano**, Takumi Ito, and Jun Suzuki
*ACL 2024 Student Research Workshop*

## Honors and Awards

**Outstanding Paper Award** 2025
The 31st Annual Meeting of the Association for Natural Language Processing (NLP 2025)
*Awarded to top 14 / 765 submissions*

**BOOST Program for next-generation AI areas (JST)** 2025
Broadening Opportunities for Outstanding young researchers and doctoral students in STrategic areas
*Research Fellow (subsidized by JST)*

**Encouragement Award** 2025
The 31st Annual Meeting of the Association for Natural Language Processing (NLP 2025)
*Awarded to top 20 / 487 eligible submissions*

**Encouragement Award** 2024
The 30th Annual Meeting of the Association for Natural Language Processing (NLP 2024)
*Awarded to top 18 / 427 eligible submissions*

## Academic Activities

**Reviewer.** ARR, TMLR, ICML (2026), NeurIPS (2026), ICASSP (2026, 2027), ICLR (2027).

**Talk.** Expanding Language Models for Speech and Beyond.
Speech Lunch, Carnegie Mellon University, Oct 8, 2026.

## Skills

**Tools.** Python, PyTorch, distributed training, Linux, Git, Slurm, Docker/Singularity

**Languages.** Japanese (native), English (professional working proficiency)